CHAPTER 20

PUNCHED IN THE FACE

23 November 2006

AUSTRALIA vs ENGLAND, 1st Test, Gabba, *Brisbane*

Australia won by 277 runs (Australia won the series 5-0)

Something hasn't felt right from the start. I am back into the team occasionally but struggling to trust my body still after the stress fracture. The team too is becoming splintered after the 2005 Ashes. Michael Vaughan and Simon Jones are injured. Freddie Flintoff is distracted from his feats of game-changing spells and innings by the weight of captaincy. The build-up too has had all the red flags of a disaster-in-waiting. For one, there's a heaviness and seriousness to the anticipation. There's so much talk in team meetings, in interviews, in the media noise outside, about the importance of winning this series. And yet, it has felt like there's been little discussion on how we're actually going to do that. Non-cricketing agendas have dominated the conversations: what suits we are going to wear on the plane out, for one. There have been endless discussions about it, Ashley Giles eventually winning out on his theory that we need to look smart, professional and unified.

We feel anything but as we take to the field. The 2005 series has motivated the Australians more than ever and – with Shane Warne, Glenn McGrath and Justin Langer all retiring at the end of the year – the toughest, most important tour in English cricket is almost doubled in difficulty by an incredibly motivated Australian team and public on a revenge mission. They turn up sharp and thirsty for payback. We turn up off the flight in suits.